

When Am I?: How Historiography Can Inform Positionality in HCI

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Abstract

Positionality is rapidly becoming an accepted and necessary aspect of conducting well contextualised and reflected research in HCI, yet it remains controversial. This short paper compares and contrasts the nature of positionality in HCI against the position of a historian and their facts, highlighting some similarities but more importantly demonstrating the impact that time and reflection can have on the way the author situates themselves and their work in the broader trends of society and culture. We take two pieces of respected and long-standing historiography and use them to situate current discourse of positionality in HCI to reveal methods, techniques and perspectives from the study of History that can be leveraged by the HCI practitioner.

CCS Concepts

• **Human-centered computing** → HCI theory, concepts and models; • **Social and professional topics** → History of computing theory.

Keywords

Positionality, Historiography

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1 Introduction

Human Computer Interaction (HCI) often looks to other disciplines of science and arts for method, theory or inspiration - anyone who attends a major HCI conference will understand it is a remarkably diverse field of the computational sciences. The rise of digital humanities has led to a significant amount of HCI being deployed into historical contexts and environments [4, 7, 11], but rarely has the flow in data driven qualitative research gone the other way; few methods of historical study have been overtly adopted by HCI

practitioners compared to, say, methods of sociology, art, or human geography¹. This appears to be a missed opportunity, with the modern inclusion of reflective and self-analytical study when conducting interactive research. Methods such as diary study [8], auto-ethnography [6], observation, analysis of textiles and sentimental designs [13] and more all produce sources that would look familiar to any student of History.

Similarly, the growth of the positionality statement would catch the eye of a contemporary social Historian, as it reflects an adage often employed: *study the historian, as well as the history*. Positionality and positionality statements in HCI refers to the inclusion of an author's background and the context in which they conducted their study. When presenting their research, knowing the author's provenance when designing and conducting it allows the reader to make more developed conclusions from their results [10]. Recently, in concordance with the emergence of reflection in the ACM sphere [2], positionality statements have become more common as a way for authors to pre-empt commentary on their work, enable the reader a depth of insight, especially when working with minority, disenfranchised or differently-abled and diverse participant pools when the author may or may not belong to them [12]. The examination of an author's background, context, potential demographics, or social standing when analysing their work is not exclusive to the social sciences, but is also a technique of the humanities; a student of classics, history, poetry or theology would be harshly critiqued if they did not consider '*who wrote the piece and why*' when situating it in its context, a method known as historiography; the study of written history and of historians.

Here, we examine two pieces of famous historiography from the 20th century, EH Carr's *What Is History* [1], and the quasi-response that is Richard J Evans' *In Defence Of History* [3] alongside Singh et al's comprehensive review of the current state of positionality in HCI [12]. Due to the constraints of this format, we will be illustrative in our comparisons and takeaways for the reader as opposed to comprehensive, aiming to provoke consideration rather than present a new paradigm entirely. We explore two key chapters from both books intended to cover the same theoretical ground, and project this through discourse of contemporary position and reflection in HCI practice to provide the reader with a brief provocation on how methods of history can inform methods of HCI. Through these chapters, we provide a perspective to the *reader* of a piece of work and to the *author* on how they are presenting their positionality. The key contribution of this work is to provide a suggestion



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¹This is referring to the style of qualitative research seen in venues such as CHI, CSCW and DIS that utilises positionality statements and is referred to throughout this paper, rather than research specifically on the history of HCI - a distinction of scope we are making explicit here

rooted in empirical and postmodernist historical theory to readers and authors of positionality in HCI who have concerns grappling with what to include, the purpose of clarifying their positionality, and ways to overcome potential issues brought up in Singh et al's review.

2 Sources and Motivation

For this short exploration, we rely on three key sources: EH Carr's 1961 book *What Is History* [1]; Richard J Evans' 1997 book *In Defence Of History* [3]; Singh et al's 2025 conference paper *Exploring Positionality in HCI: Perspectives, Trends and Challenges* [12]. These sources have been chosen for their illustrative qualities: Carr and Evans' books provide broad perspectives on historiography and cover the last century of historical writing, being well recognised as an essential part of a student's reading in traditional historiography methods and theory [5], as well as covering near identical grounds allowing for transparent comparison. Singh et al's work has been selected for being (at the time of publication) the most up to date and comprehensive examination of positionality in the HCI field, examining the volume, style and rigour of statements in published work over the last decade. As such, it provides us with a valid comparison and reference point for our application of historical method.

2.1 EH Carr, *What Is History?*

Carr's 1961 book is actually comprised of a series of lectures the author gave at Cambridge University the same year as part of the GM Trevelyan Lectures. The book covers Carr's opposition to what he describes as a "fetishistic obsession" with primary source material from 19th and early 20th century historians, and his advocacy for a move towards a more postmodernist perspective [5]. As such, Carr adopts a light tone akin to a conversation with the reader, presumed to be an early level student of History. The result is a somewhat polemical series of short chapters where Carr heavily utilises examples from previous historians to emphasise his perspective that reading and writing history is as much about subconscious interpretation and societal influences as it is about primary materials.

2.2 Richard J Evans, *In Defence Of History*

Unlike Carr's work, Evans' book is a deliberately and carefully constructed piece of historiography intended to provide a balanced and updated view on the kinds of claims that Carr, his predecessors and Evans' contemporaries make. The reason these books have been chosen as a pair is because Evans' intentionally titles many of his chapters identically to Carr, and covers the same ground, but with the aim to provide a more nuanced and comprehensive historiographical stance that examines the last 200 years of historical writing [3]. Evans' disagreements with Carr are frequent but not dismissive, and the additional 36 years of historical discourse are laid out in detail for the reader. These two pieces of work taken together form a good image of how historians think, write and educate the reader from different perspectives and schools of thought.

2.3 Singh et al, *Exploring Positionality in HCI: Perspectives, Trends and Challenges*

Published in CHI 2025, this paper consisted of a literature review and a survey of HCI practitioners to provide a comprehensive overview of the current state of positionality. Singh et al highlight the trends found in current positionality statements found in CHI publications and examine perspectives from experts in the field - reviewing over 200 papers and surveying 75 individuals. We use this paper as our reference point to draw out where the existing themes of positionality are highlighted by Singh et al as areas for improvement, reflection or codification from the HCI community as a way to explore possible avenues for historiographical method to be utilised. We acknowledge that there are other commentaries on positionality and HCI, but for the sake of utility and brevity this is the key source used in this short paper.

3 The Historian And His Facts

Our first port of call is to the understanding of what these historians consider constitutes *fact*, and the ways that this would impact the *reader* - in HCI, the positionality statement is included to for the benefit of the reader, for them to understand some social and contextual factors that the author believes may influence the end product of research. However, in their survey results [5.2] Singh et al highlight in their survey that positionality statements are often included without definite reason, and researchers can hold reservations over their potential to be leveraged negatively. Here, we demonstrate a divergence in the belief that facts are, by this logic, malleable by the author (intentionally or unintentionally).

In his initial chapter, Carr utilises a primary example (aside from a rather macabre anecdote about gingerbread vendor meeting his untimely death in Victorian England [1], p. 7) from a piece of history found in English University reading lists regarding a Weimar Republic Minister's time in office as foreign minister [14]. Carr establishes several points at which a historical "fact" may have been established under the impressions of the author: The original piece being reconstructed by an aide from the Minister's personal files, thus emphasising the role of the Minister in debate and policy construction; The account being written prior to Nazi control of Germany, thus having a considerably more positive view on the success of the Weimar Republic than if it had been written in WW2; The omission for the most part of relations to the Soviet Union, as this was not a primary point of concern prior to the war but rapidly became of note in the years following; The translation and abridgement of the original by the English historian, thereby choosing what information was deemed important enough for inclusion to be taught to English history students.

As such, Carr adopts an empirical perspective and is insistent that any student should study the *historian* before (or alongside) studying their *history*, as he believes that the idea of a "fact" is, in-fact, simply a manifestation of the historian. Carr uses several examples both from notable historians and his own studies to impress upon the reader that a historical fact only becomes such when it has been chosen, established and agreed upon by a historian and his successors, and as such enters the pantheon of "historical facts".

The result of this example is a reader left believing that any piece of historical writing is beholden to the author's background,

education and other factors, and as such the historian is worthy of as much study as their history writing. This, in a way, aligns with some aspects of positionality statements that we find in Singh et al's review and in some HCI publications; that the author's internal and external biases have such great an influence on the way data is interpreted that "facts" must be scrutinised in tandem with "authors", and that these influences have a significant impact on the validity of the research presented: "*Participants felt that positionality can allow researchers to be transparent about their personal and social contexts which may have an impact on the way they approach research, collect data and interpret findings*" [12].

This demonstrates a parallel between empirical historical thinking and a use-case for positionality. It does not, however, address a key concern highlighted by Singh et al that some authors feel positionality can be used negatively, either to attempt to sway a reviewer or an audience towards a certain interpretation of analysis or that an author's position may be used to discredit their analysis. For this, we could potentially look towards Evan's perspective on fact.

Evans, in contrast to Carr, adopts a perspective that places historical fact and evidence at the centre of a historical study, and the historian's role is to construct a narrative *informed* by their current position but as part of a wider narrative: "*Doing historical research is rather like doing a jigsaw puzzle where all the pieces are not present in one box but are scattered over the house in several boxes*" - [3] p. 159

In this analogy, a study may form part of a picture but will never *not* be the picture printed on the box; when one has a jigsaw of a train, there may be an image of clouds, grass or people that present a certain narrative, but it cannot be manipulated by the author to look like a dog. This is, in part, a response to historiographical research that is entirely *historian* focused without little to no primary source analysis. Evans claims that whilst this can produce interesting commentary, primary sources are necessary to a distinct and evolving discourse, illustrated in two examples regarding famous original documents: Charles Beard's re-interpretation of the American Constitution as a *economic* document rather than an *ideological* one had a profound impact on American studies and the perceptions of the Founding Fathers, and the discovery of the Dead Sea Scrolls in the mid-20th century radically changed Biblical Studies. Both directly impacted the way the primary source is now viewed by current historians, but was not through historiographical discourse. Evans rejection of the postmodernist perspective is based on the notion that placing primary sources and secondary sources on equal planes for analysis is flawed, as it reduces the necessity to actually understand and examine the primary data and materials on which history is written.

Transposing this to positionality in HCI, this would indicate to the reader of a piece that as long as an author has indicated and demonstrated a rigorous method, sound analysis and an appropriate write-up of their findings, we should place our trust in the results and contributions of the research. That it was performed by a certain demographic may allude to one corner of our puzzle, but it is categorical that (as long as the research is good) the research presents *facts* as we know them to further our understanding. For those in Singh's survey that highlighted concerns over the potential

positionality statements have to negatively influence a reader, a reviewer or an author, including this perspective as a recognised caveat could mitigate this feeling.

As such, we present two historical perspectives that can be taken in tandem for the HCI practitioner:

- When you read something, you should be encouraged to understand its provenance.
- That being said, if the method and analysis chosen and applied is appropriate then it can be the primary area of examination, regardless of positionality inclusion.

4 Society And The Individual

The second chapter being examined here is to provide a perspective to the *author* of a piece of HCI research, about the purpose their positionality statement has and the way it is presented to the *reader*. Carr and Evans discuss the more entangled aspects of constructing a historical narrative, and pose questions over the extent to which a piece of history cannot be removed from the time and context in which it was written - this has implications for an author in HCI space who includes positionality to try and explain this to a reader, but will undoubtedly run into issues of self-constructing an image that they do not have all of the pieces of when attempting to convey their position in writing. This addresses concerns over the necessity of whether or not to include a positionality statement, and the information that it should hold [5.3.2 in [12]].

In this chapter, Carr emphasises the society *around* a historian when they are researching, analysing and presenting their work; his primary claim is that the practitioner of history is completely and unavoidably entangled in the culture, political climate, education structure and belief systems of the society in which they grew up and conducted their research - these seen and unseen influences only become clear with *time* and *reflection* from future historians who are detached from this society and can more clearly see the strands of influence in the written product. Again, to demonstrate this point Carr provides us with some examples: he highlights Grote's history of Ancient Greece, in Carr's view clearly written with an effort to align the progressive Victorian middle classes with the much admired Athenian Democracy, as a piece of historical writing that tells us as much about the author's own time than it does about Athens. Similarly, he provides examples of Whiggish historians such as Namier and Trevelyan writing that history is always on the incline, society always progressing for the better, a viewpoint that does not hold up well with the incoming First and Second World Wars, an aspect the authors were unaware of; their histories are written to provide stepping stones of progress to the present, demonstrating a continuously improving society.

This argument, again, aligns with the HCI concept of self-reflection and acknowledge when conducting research - an argument that leads many to include positionality in an attempt to pre-empt a discussion on context and societal impact on the analysis and results of work. It also, however, has further implications: Carr demonstrates in a way that HCI cannot (through a longer time frame) that the social and cultural context in which one constructs their work emerges *over time* - the authors he lists did not overtly state their analytical machinations for transposing their own time onto

a narrative of the past, as the general themes of their surroundings are only clear to us as viewers from the future. As such, when we examine efforts found in positionality statements identified by Singh et al that go further than demographic information, statements that attempt to construct and present an image of the author and their research context comprehensively, we must acknowledge that this is an incomplete picture and that the full position may only become clear with hindsight and retrospect [6.3 [12], [9]]. Adopting this perspective could be seen as a benefit, as it would allow researchers to openly acknowledge that their given positionality is only their personal and reflective understanding of their context and that perceptions of the work will change as larger historical trends and narratives of the 21st century emerge; authors should be encouraged to look beyond "*who am I?*" and incorporate "*when am I?*"

Evans, however, argues that this belief of being unable to disconnect the historian from their society and to always place such a lens on it is firmly rooted in 20th century idealism that history should be *comprehensive* and as such historians made the effort to construct all-encompassing narratives of a time period. The modern exploration of all facets of history (women's history, social history, sports history, and more niche topics) means that this is no longer a necessity, and over-emphasising a discussion on secondary source texts and discourse could lead to a neglect of the events that that "actually happened". Evans uses nationality as an example of this divergence of society and the history studies: he notes a marked increase in African, Asian and South American topic modules available to the British University student of history, converging with a decline of study of the "Great Men" of European tradition. This transition, Evans argues, produces experts in history who utilise their *lack* of connection to a society to produce alternative perspectives on traditional narratives - in this event, there is often return to the study of primary source material to construct narratives over the study of extant histories to produce historiographical analysis.

Transposing this to reflections raised by Singh et al that a "*narrow focus on positionality could inadvertently limit our ability to innovate and address the complex challenges of HCI?*", we see that this concern has already been a topic of historical discourse addressed by Evans. Evans encourages authors to acknowledge that their work does not have to be comprehensive and can instead embrace the lens with which it was written as a way to lessen the requirement for discourse on provenance and societal impact; by taking a piece of research as (to use an earlier analogy) a puzzle piece instead of a comprehensive and encompassing answer to a grand question, we lessen the need to view positionality as defining aspect of the conclusions found in the work.

Again, from these perspectives we present two key takeaways to an author of HCI work:

- The context in which you write is important to consider, *but* it is difficult to accurately represent this context when you are the one living in it
- Whilst it is important to consider, an over-emphasis on discourse can lead to a neglect of primary source information - adopting a less comprehensive perspective on work can

allow it to be read as part of a wider understanding of a narrative.

5 Conclusion

Table 1: Summary of Issues Raised

Historical Idea	Comparative Positionality Factor
One should consider the provenance of work prior to/whilst reading it	Positionality allows for transparency of personal and social contexts
If method and analysis are appropriate, they merit primary attention	Can positional statements influence readership of a paper negatively?
The context in which you write can be difficult to establish impartially	What is the utility and efficacy of positionality beyond demographics?
Over-emphasis on discourse can lead to a neglect of primary material	Does a narrow focus inadvertently limit innovation?

This short exploration of applying a historiographical perspective to the idea of positionality in HCI aims to provide readers with an opportunity for discussion, reflection and analysis regarding their own work and the work of their peers in the community. Through examining issues raised by Singh et al's comprehensive survey on positionality in HCI, we can see that many of these concerns have direct parallels to discussions led in historiographical discourse - referring to key sources in this domain may help to guide discussion in this emergence of positionality and the concerns surrounding it. We provide a stepping stone towards novel discussion of applying historical methods to emerging ideas in the HCI space through two key sources in the area, and demonstrate the ways in which HCI practitioners can learn from them. Through this discussion we point at ways that a reader of work in this space can apply historical methods beyond reading a positionality statement by considering the context in which it was written but also examining the data as a representation of *fact*, and how an author can consider their own representations both within and outside of the context in which they were constructed.

Exactly how these methods should be implemented in practice is beyond the scope of this examination, but there is evident potential for the development of cross-community toolkits that borrow from historical literature. Collaborative discussion between purely historical practitioners and HCI practitioners could prove fruitful, and those looking to expand their current perspective on positionality or are currently uncertain about its efficacy should be encouraged to read historiographical literature, such as the works pointed to in this short paper.

It is important to note that this provocation is not negative towards the concept, inclusion or discussion of positionality in HCI; it instead intends to spark discussion and discourse on the way positionality is utilised, and to provide an alternative perspective drawing from a discipline that has not previously been drawn from often in HCI spheres of study. Overall, this short investigation shows that

drawing from historical and historiographical sources can hopefully produce a new avenue for nuanced and well developed discourse on the role of the researcher in conducting, analysing and presenting facts of research.

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